HIDDEN BOX EARRING STAND

Andy Coates uses up some offcuts by turning this earring stand

PHOTOGRAPHS BY ANDY COATES

One of my staple production items is made from 85mm square lignum vitae (*Guiaiacum officinale*) stock and the stock is always delivered overlength because that is how it is supplied. My customer has no use for the offcuts, so they are the 'cream on the milk' and I get to keep them. The trouble I have is what to make from them. I don't particularly like lignum; it can be oily and difficult to get a decent finish on, it can look a little 'old-fashioned' for my tastes, and recent batches have had a number of faults that have rendered the blanks unusable for anything other than pen blanks! I have however, built up quite a supply of offcuts and decided I should use them before I get too many. They are usually about 90 x 90 x 190mm, so whatever I use them for needs to be a small item, and small items always suggest craft fair stock to me.

I decided to make one of my regular stock items, an earring stand with a hidden box, which I usually make from branch wood yew (*Taxus baccata*). I designed this stand quite some time ago now and the main reason for the hidden box was to simply add interest and value to what is a pretty ordinary stock item that can only command a price within a very tight band. The addition of the hidden box means I can have two versions, one without a box at price A and one with a hidden box at an increased price, B. And so far it has worked well. They always sell.

Like anything we make to sell, the difference between the run-of-the-mill and the special is attention to detail, and this project is a good example of this philosophy. Some of the steps may seem like overkill and if they do to you, then please feel free to leave them out and finish the project to your own taste, but if you persevere and complete the stand in the prescribed manner then you end up with a finished object that looks and feels considered and is finished to a high standard.

In order to complete the box I use a homemade jam chuck for three of the steps. You can make one of these for yourself quite simply, and once made you will find other uses for it over and above those detailed here. I have included a drawing of the jam chuck, and detailed the making within the project.

You could use almost any wood species for this project, but it works best with something strong-grained as it is the grain alignment that helps to hide the box; this wouldn't work quite so well with a bland wood species. There are also opportunities for some further design features, such as texturing on the upper 'umbrella', or around the base, or maybe some colour, gilding or metal leaf decoration. As ever this project is intended more to get you thinking than simply copying a pattern.

ANDY COATES

Andy is on the Register of Professional Turners (RPT) and is Chairman of the AWGB. He is a professional woodturner and has a workshop and gallery in Suffolk. He mostly makes one-off pieces, but like any jobbing woodturner, is just as likely to be found doing small batch runs, antique restorations or any number of strange commissions. He also demonstrates and teaches turning.

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